Before the Distance: The Story of John & Erin

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Before the Distance: The Story of John & Erin

Seconds Into Thunder

Scene 1: The Three-Minute Bell

Date: 2004-09-17 at 19:00 America/New_York

The dual-motor drive base of John's power wheelchair hummed in a steady, low-frequency harmony with Erin's chair beside him as they crested the final paved incline leading up from the Drillfield to the limestone archway of Newman Hall.

Anyone who tried to navigate Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute in a manual chair learned the hard way within forty-eight hours of freshman orientation that Blacksburg was carved into the side of the Blue Ridge Mountains. Between the sweeping bowl of the Drillfield, the steep Ironstone steps climbing toward the engineering quad, and the long, relentless grades running down to Progress Street NW, torque and battery reserves were non-negotiable.

John eased his thumb off the rubberized joystick mounted on his right armrest, bringing his chair to a smooth, zero-radius halt just inside the warm atrium of the Student Union. Beside him, his fraternal twin sister Erin tapped her own joystick into neutral and reached up to adjust her round tortoiseshell glasses, her long wavy brown hair catching the warm amber glow of the hall sconces.

“Check your battery gauge,” Erin said, glancing over at his armrest console. “That climb up from the chemistry annex always eats an extra bar.”

“Four green LEDs out of five,” John replied, adjusting his own matching tortoiseshell frames and smoothing the hem of his maroon sweater. He looked down the second-floor corridor toward the open double doors of the lounge, where a hand-lettered poster taped to the limestone pillar read *FRIDAY NIGHT CAMPUS SPEED-DATING MIXER — 7:00 PM*. “Which means I physically have enough range to turn around, take the elevator back down, and roll all the way back to the apartment.”

“Not a chance,” Erin grinned, nudging the rubber bumper of her footplate lightly against the side of his caster wheel. “You promised me one hour out of the lab. Twenty tables, three minutes per round. If it’s a disaster, we hit the dining hall for late-night waffle fries and call it field research.”

They rolled side by side into the Second-Floor Lounge. The student activities volunteers had arranged twenty small circular tables in a wide ring around the room, leaving generous four-foot lanes between them so both John and Erin could maneuver their power chairs into the odd-numbered anchor spots without scraping a single chair leg. Erin claimed Table 1 near the windows overlooking Alumni Mall, while John parked at Table 4, flipping the standard wooden chair aside and locking his drive wheels into position flush against the tabletop.

At the front of the room, a sophomore wearing a CPI Student Activities polo stood behind a rolling media cart equipped with a dual-deck AudioStar CD system and two amplified PA speakers.

“Alright, everyone, welcome!” the organizer called out into a handheld microphone, tapping the grille twice. “Instead of using an obnoxious kitchen timer or a whistle to signal the end of each rotation, we’re keeping things civilized tonight. Every round is timed to Track 3 here—*Seconds Into Forever*. It’s an eighty-five-BPM power ballad, and it runs exactly three minutes and zero seconds. When the synth pad fades out at the end of the song, you thank your partner and rotate one table to the left!”

He pressed play on the first round. Warm, sparkling synthesizer pads and clean electric guitar arpeggios floated out of the speakers:

The clock is ticking on the classroom wall But time stands still here in the hall I saw your face and the world went blurred The sweetest song that I ever heard No need to run and no need to hide I’m pulling up a chair right by your side

John let his shoulders drop an inch. The first three rotations were pleasant, polite, and entirely predictable—three minutes with a civil engineering major debating bridge trusses, three minutes with an architecture student sketching on her napkin, and three minutes with a quiet girl from Roanoke who spent two of the minutes asking about the top speed of his power chair on the Drillfield paths.

Across the room at Table 1, Erin caught his eye as the third round's sustained synth chord faded out. She flashed him a quick thumbs-up from her armrest.

See? her expression said. *Harmless.*

"Alright, folks, rotate to Round Four!" the organizer announced over the PA.

Scene 2: Table Four

Date: 2004-09-17 at 19:20 America/New_York

A woman in a fitted black leather jacket stepped into the open space opposite Table 4 and pulled out the wooden chair across from John's power wheelchair.

Unlike the previous three students, who had glanced nervously at their name tags or at the empty floor space where his chair was parked, she didn't look down at his drive wheels or his joystick controller. She rested her elbows on the small round table, leaned forward into his immediate field of view, and locked her dark eyes directly onto his behind his tortoiseshell glasses.

"I've been waiting three tables to get to this side of the room," she said, her voice low, smooth, and unhurried. "I'm Valerie."

"John," he said, offering a polite smile. "Wait—weren't you over by Table 9 a minute ago? That's five tables back."

"I traded numbers with two girls in line so I wouldn't have to wait," Valerie replied without missing a beat, flashing a sharp, magnetic smile that made John's pulse jump. "Everyone else in this room is making small talk about syllabus week. You've been actually listening to every person who sat down in front of you. You're rare, John."

Up at the front media cart, the student organizer was juggling a stack of sign-in clipboards with one hand while reaching blindly for the "|<<" restart button on the AudioStar CD player with the other. In his rush, his thumb missed the back button by half an inch and jammed down hard on ">>|" instead—skipping right past Track 3 and landing on Track 4.

For ten seconds, a lush, cinematic Vangelis-style analog synthesizer swell filled the lounge. Half the room assumed it was an extended intro to the ballad.

Then—*CRASH.*

An explosive acoustic drum fill and a blistering C-minor synthesizer stab tore through the PA speakers at 150 beats per minute, followed by a roaring, high-gain stadium guitar riff that rattled the water pitchers on the tables:

The clock on the wall is a guillotine blade Cutting down the promises we never made I see you standing there across the crowded floor Like a lighthouse burning on a midnight shore!

"Whoa, wrong track!" the organizer yelped, dropping his clipboards as papers scattered across the carpet. He fumbled with the volume knob, accidentally turning the master fader up before the remote slipped under the cart.

Across the room, students laughed and shouted over the sudden wall of stadium rock, waiting for him to fix the deck.

At Table 4, Valerie didn't flinch or look toward the speakers. Instead, she reached across the narrow tabletop and placed her hand directly over John's wrist where it rested near his joystick controller. Her palm was warm, her grip surprisingly firm.

Don't tell me to wait, don't tell me to stop I'm a runaway train and I'm blowing the top The neon signs are flashing "Danger" in red But I'd rather be living than safe and dead Hold on tight, baby, don't let go We're dancing on the edge of the volcano!

"Leave it!" Valerie laughed over the roaring chorus, her eyes shining as she leaned closer to John. "Everyone else gets a polite little three-minute lullaby. You and I get the storm. Tell me that isn't a sign."

John's heart hammered against his ribs in time with the 150-BPM kick drum. Used to being treated either as an academic study partner or as a Fragile Accommodation Request by strangers on campus, the sheer, undivided intensity of her focus felt intoxicating. He didn't register the red flags in the way she had skipped the rotation rules, or the way her fingers were already subtly resting over his chair's control hand, or the literal warning screaming from the speakers.

He just smiled back into the spotlight of her attention.

"Yeah," John said over the thunder of the guitars. "Maybe it is."

Before the Distance

Scene 1: The Frayed Mask

Date: 2004-11-18 at 17:15 America/New_York

Cold November rain slanted sideways beneath the concrete canopy of the CPI Transit Center, drumming against the steel roof shelter and pooling in dark, oily puddles along the boarding curb of University Mall.

Erin sat in her power wheelchair near the Bay 1 route sign, her maroon CPI windbreaker zipped to her chin and her hands tucked into fleece-lined gloves. Every thirty seconds, her eyes flicked from the glowing amber LED countdown board overhead down the long, wet concrete incline leading up from the academic quad.

It had been sixty-two days since the speed-dating mixer in Newman Hall.

In the first two weeks after that Friday night, Valerie had seemed like a whirlwind romance. She had walked beside John's power chair to every class, brought him coffee at the library, and praised Erin as "the coolest twin sister on campus."

Then, week three had arrived, and the perimeter had begun closing like a vise.

First came the canceled Friday dinners on Progress Street—always explained away by a sudden "migraine" or an "emergency" that required John's undivided attention at Valerie's off-campus duplex. Next came the phone calls where Valerie's voice was audible in the background, coaching John on what to say, followed by nights when

John’s cell phone went straight to voicemail for thirty-six hours at a stretch. When Erin had finally bumped into them outside the bookstore the previous week, Valerie had answered every single question directed at John, smiling coldly while resting both hands on the rear push-handles of John’s power wheelchair as if she owned the chassis.

Erin’s jaw tightened as two figures finally appeared at the bottom of the rain-slicked pedestrian ramp.

John’s power wheelchair was climbing the grade at half its normal speed. Even from forty feet away, Erin could see why: Valerie was walking right beside his left wheel, one hand clamped tightly around the upright frame of his backrest while the other held a single black umbrella angled entirely over her own head, leaving cold rainwater to drip steadily off the rims of John’s tortoiseshell glasses.

As they rolled under the concrete shelter of Bay 1, Erin felt a cold knot twist in her stomach.

John looked hollowed out. Dark, bruised shadows hung beneath his eyes. His shoulders were hunched inward over his armrests, his gaze fixed on the wet concrete three feet ahead of his front casters—a quiet surrender in a crowded place. He wore a polite, practiced smile as he looked up at Erin, but the edges of the mask were completely frayed.

“Hey, Er,” John said quietly, his voice raspy with exhaustion.

“You’re soaking wet, John,” Erin said, driving her chair forward half a length so she was directly facing her brother. She pulled a dry microfiber cloth from her side pouch and held it out for his glasses. “I thought we were meeting inside the Newman atrium at four-thirty so we could go over the thermodynamics packet together.”

Before John could reach for the cloth, Valerie stepped half a pace forward, positioning her hip right beside John’s armrest controller.

“We had errands to run, Erin,” Valerie said, her tone syrupy and sharp all at once. She took the cloth out of Erin’s hand and wiped the rain off John’s frames herself, as though John’s own arms didn’t work. “And honestly, John is completely burned out from carrying your shared study load this semester. He doesn’t have time to ride back to Progress Street with you tonight. We only stopped by the Transit Center so he could drop off your textbook before we head back to my place for the weekend.”

Erin didn’t look at Valerie. She kept her eyes locked straight on her twin brother’s face.

When Valerie mentioned going back to her place for the weekend, John’s right hand —resting near his joystick—flinched Almost imperceptibly, his knuckles turning white against the black foam pad. He didn’t argue. He didn’t correct her. He just looked down at his lap, reaching into his backpack with trembling fingers to pull out the heavy hardcover textbook.

In twenty years of sharing a life, John had never once flinched at the thought of going home.

He's trapped, Erin realized, the cold math locking into place in her chest. *She's isolating him for the entire weekend, and he thinks he has to endure it.*

Scene 2: When the Steel Doors Close

Date: 2004-11-18 at 17:30 America/New_York

The hydraulic pump beneath the front door of the Blue Ridge Transit coach whined, a mechanical two-second warning before the driver raised the aluminum ramp.

Inside the warm bus, Erin's right hand hovered over the joystick of her power wheelchair. Through the rain-streaked glass, she watched Valerie's manicured fingers tighten into the fabric of John's wet sleeve. Valerie was already pivoting toward the upper pedestrian ramp that led back to the graduate parking lot—and to another night behind a closed apartment door where John's phone would stay face-down on a kitchen counter.

John looked back toward the bus one last time. His glasses were fogged at the edges, his shoulders hunched against the freezing Blacksburg rain, his right hand limp and motionless beside his controller. He looked like a man watching the last lifeboat pull away from a sinking pier because someone had convinced him he didn't deserve a seat on it.

Not tonight, Erin thought. *Not my brother.*

"Hold the ramp!" Erin called out, her voice ringing clear and sharp down the rubberized aisle of the coach.

Before the driver could touch the toggle switch, Erin pulled her joystick straight back. Her dual electric motors engaged with a deep, authoritative hum. She backed out of the wheelchair bay, executed a tight zero-turn pivot on the ribbed floor plates near the farebox, and drove straight down the wet aluminum ramp onto the concrete platform of Bay 1.

Cold rain pelted her maroon CPI jacket and speckled the lenses of her glasses. She didn't slow down until her front caster wheels stopped three inches from John's footrests, positioning the heavy steel frame of her power wheelchair directly between her twin brother and Valerie.

Valerie blinked, her practiced, patient smile faltering for a fraction of a second before snapping back into place. "Erin, sweetheart, the bus is about to leave. You're going to miss your ride back to Progress Street."

"I'm not missing anything," Erin said. She didn't look at Valerie. She looked straight into John's eyes and reached across the gap between their armrests, covering his cold, trembling right hand with her warm palm. "John. Put your chair in gear. You're coming home with me."

John stared at her, his breath catching in his throat. "Erin, I—Valerie and I have dinner on the stove, and we still need to finish going over—"

“Now,” Valerie cut in, her voice dropping half an octave as the honeyed veneer cracked. She stepped forward, trying to wedge her umbrella between the twins’ chairs. “John is an adult, Erin, and we already have plans for the evening. It really isn’t healthy the way you keep trying to—”

“Take your hand off his sleeve,” Erin said.

She didn’t shout. She didn’t have to. There was an immovable, bedrock certainty in her voice—the same quiet steel that had carried both of them through nineteen years of hospital corridors, physical therapy gyms, and steep mountain grades.

Valerie froze, her fingers still pinched around John’s cuff. Around them, three undergrads waiting under the concrete canopy turned their heads to watch. Under the bright amber glow of the bus’s destination sign, Valerie’s favorite weapon—secrecy—had just evaporated.

“John,” Erin said softly, squeezing his fingers until the tremor in his hand steadied against hers. “Look at me. Remember the fourth-grade hill behind the middle school when my battery cable snapped in the sleet? You hooked your tow strap to my frame and burned out half your motor pulling both of us to the top. You don’t owe anyone your disappearance. Come with me. Right now.”

John looked down at Erin’s hand over his. Then he looked at Valerie’s white-knuckled grip on his jacket sleeve—at the flash of cold, undisguised fury in Valerie’s eyes now that the polite mask had slipped away.

Something inside John’s chest unlocked.

Without a word to Valerie, John pulled his arm free from her grasp. His right thumb found his joystick. The green LEDs on his power base flared to life, and his motors hummed in unison with his sister’s.

“John, if you get on that bus right now, don’t bother calling me tonight,” Valerie hissed, stepping back onto the wet brick as her composure fractured completely. “I mean it, John!”

“Go ahead, John,” Erin said, reversing her chair back up the yellow-bordered aluminum ramp to clear his path. “Right behind me.”

John pushed his joystick forward. His tires gripped the diamond-plate aluminum of the ramp, climbing out of the cold November rain and into the warm, amber-lit cabin of the Blue Ridge Transit coach. He wheeled into the second securement bay right beside Erin’s chair, his wet sleeve brushing hers as the driver flipped the hydraulic switch.

The aluminum ramp folded upward with a heavy metallic clank. The dual-leaf steel doors hissed shut, sealing out the wind, the rain, and the woman standing rigid and furious beneath the concrete canopy of Bay 1.

As the bus pulled away from the curb and merged onto University Mall, John let out a long, shuddering breath and leaned his head back against his headrest. Across the narrow aisle between their chairs, Erin reached out and took his hand again—and this time, she didn’t let go until they reached Progress Street.

Sanctuary in the Storm

Scene 1: The Locked Perimeter

Date: 2004-11-19 at 20:00 America/New_York

The November storm hadn't broken; it had only deepened, lashing freezing rain against the double-paned front window of Erin's ground-floor apartment on Progress Street NW.

Inside, the apartment smelled of toasted sourdough, cinnamon tea, and the familiar, ozone-clean warmth of two charging power wheelchairs parked side by side near the hallway outlet.

John sat in his desk chair by the living room radiator, a thick flannel blanket draped across his knees and his glasses resting on the coffee table beside an untouched mug of tea. Five feet away, on the kitchen counter, his flip phone vibrated against the laminate. It was the nineteenth time it had buzzed since noon. Every message wore a different costume: three paragraphs of wounded martyrdom at one o'clock, a clipped demand that he return a borrowed textbook at three, a sudden, tearful apology at five, and a cold ultimatum by seven.

Each time the little plastic casing hummed against the counter, a phantom reflex twitched in John's shoulders—the conditioned urge to apologize, to explain himself, to fix the weather inside someone else's head before the lightning struck.

Footsteps didn't cross the hardwood floor; instead, the quiet, steady whirr of Erin's indoor mobility setup glided into the kitchen. She didn't ask permission. She picked up John's flip phone, pressed and held the red power key until the little blue LCD screen went dark, and dropped the silent phone into the ceramic cookie jar beside the toaster.

"Out of range," Erin said, setting the ceramic lid back in place with a decisive clink.

She wheeled into the living room, carrying a plate of grilled cheese cut into triangles, and set it on the coffee table in front of him. Then she locked her brakes, transferred onto the cushioned sofa beside his chair, and pulled the corner of the wool throw over her own legs.

"I didn't even see it happening," John said quietly. His voice sounded hoarse to his own ears, like an instrument that hadn't been played in months. "At the beginning, at that speed-dating table in Newman Hall, she seemed like the only person in the room who wasn't looking at the chair first. And then every week, the room just got smaller. Every time I talked to you, or missed a lab meeting, or disagreed with her about a paper, there was a price tag attached to it. Until it felt easier to just stop going anywhere at all."

Erin reached over and adjusted the collar of his sweatshirt—the exact same fussy, automatic sisterly gesture she had made since they were seven years old waiting for the school bus in the rain.

“People like Valerie don’t walk up to you wearing a warning label, John,” Erin said gently. “They test the fences first. They see how much static you’re willing to absorb to keep the peace. And because you have a good heart—because you always assume that if someone is hurting, it must be something you miscalculated—she used your own decency to lock you in.”

Outside, a gust of wind rattled the porch awning, and the distant air brakes of a Blue Ridge Transit bus sighed at the Progress Street stop.

John looked around his sister’s living room: at the wide, unobstructed thirty-six-inch doorways where neither of them ever had to apologize for the width of their wheels; at the framed photograph on the bookshelf showing the two of them in matching CPI caps on orientation day; at the heavy steel deadbolt turned squarely across the front door.

For the first time in two months, his chest rose and fell without the bracing weight of an impending argument. No one in this room was keeping score. No one was going to twist his words at midnight or punish him with silence in the morning.

“You came down the ramp for me,” John whispered, his eyes stinging as he looked at his twin sister. “The doors were already closing.”

Erin rested her head against his shoulder, her glasses bumping lightly against his temple, and laced her fingers through his.

“Of course I came down the ramp,” Erin said. “We’re twins, John. You’re my sanctuary, too. And the storm stays outside.”

Not Her

Scene 1: The Practiced Smile

Date: 2005-04-08 at 21:30 America/New_York

Spring arrived late on the plateau, trading November’s sleet for warm April rain that smelled of wet Ironstone and blooming dogwoods along University Mall.

It was nine-thirty on a Friday night outside the Newman Hall auditorium, where the spring undergraduate research symposium had just let out. John guided his power wheelchair down the interior accessibility ramp toward the east colonnade, a rolled-up poster tube tucked beside his armrest and two cups of hot cider balanced in his cupholder tray. Erin had gone ahead five minutes earlier to grab her rain poncho from the coat check near the side exit.

As John rounded the limestone pillar at the end of the breeze-way, the low murmur of the departing crowd faded behind the heavy glass doors—and a voice echoed from the recessed concrete alcove beside the service elevator.

“Come on, Erin, you don’t need to wait around for your brother every Friday night,” a smooth, practiced baritone was saying. “Honestly, it’s a little unfair how much he leans on you. A girl as brilliant as you shouldn’t have to play caretaker just because you share a birthday. Let me drive you home—we’ll load your chair in the back of my SUV, grab a drink downtown, and you can finally have a night to yourself.”

John stopped his chair in the shadow of the archway. Every nerve in his body went ice-cold, and then white-hot.

He knew that cadence. He knew the exact melody of that counterfeit concern—the flattering smile, the subtle poison designed to make love look like a burden and family look like a cage.

In the recessed alcove by the elevator, Erin sat in her power wheelchair with her back flush against the limestone wall. Standing directly in front of her footrests was Marcus Vance, a senior from the business school wearing a tailored charcoal coat. He had planted one polished leather boot on the base of the concrete ramp and rested his left hand on the top edge of the wall beside Erin’s shoulder, effectively boxing her chair into the narrow corner so she couldn’t pivot without clipping his shins.

“I told you, Marcus, I’m riding the bus home with John,” Erin said. Her voice was steady, but John knew his sister better than anyone alive—he saw the way her right thumb was tensed against her joystick, searching for a three-inch clearance that wasn’t there. “Please step back from my footrests so I can turn around.”

“I’m just saying, you let him keep you on a short leash,” Marcus said, leaning in another inch with a slow, patronizing grin that expected compliance. “Just five minutes, Erin. Tell me why you’re always running away when someone tries to—”

“She said step back.”

John’s voice cut across the limestone colonnade like a steel cable snapping under tension.

He didn’t keep his chair in indoor low-speed mode. He thumbed his controller to its highest outdoor climbing gear and drove straight up the concrete incline into the alcove. The heavy front anti-tip rollers and steel footplate of his power wheelchair surged into the narrow gap between Marcus and Erin’s chair, forcing Marcus to stumble backward half a pace or lose his ankles to two hundred and fifty pounds of rolling steel and battery torque.

John locked his brakes at a forty-five-degree angle directly in front of his twin sister, placing the full frame of his chair as a physical barricade between Marcus and Erin.

Marcus blinked, the slick smile vanishing into a flush of startled irritation. “Hey—watch where you’re driving that thing, man. Erin and I were just having a private conversation.”

“No, you weren’t,” John said. He didn’t raise his voice, and he didn’t look away. Behind the lenses of his glasses, his eyes were steady and surgical. “You were blocking her turning radius with your boot, putting your hand over her exit path, and trying to sell her the oldest lie in the book—that the people who protect her are the ones holding her back.”

Marcus let out a sharp, defensive laugh, glancing toward the empty hallway. “You’re paranoid, O’Connell. I was just offering your sister a ride home.”

“I know exactly what you were offering,” John said. “I’ve heard that script word for word. I know how it starts, I know how the flattery works, and I know what happens the moment the door closes. You can try that routine in a mirror, Marcus, or you can walk out of this building right now. Because you will never get within ten feet of my sister again. Not tonight. Not ever. Not her.”

For three seconds, the only sound in the east colonnade was the low, twin hum of two power wheelchair converters idling in unison. Behind John’s shoulder, Erin maneuvered her chair out of the corner until her wheel aligned parallel with his—a solid, two-wide phalanx of steel and shared resolve.

Marcus looked at John’s unblinking stare, then at Erin’s cold, steady gaze beside him. Whatever easy target he had imagined existed in this alcove was gone. Mutters of face-saving bravado died in his throat; he adjusted the lapels of his coat, turned on his heel, and walked briskly out the side exit into the rain.

The heavy glass door swung shut behind him.

For a long moment, neither twin spoke. Then Erin exhaled, reached across the gap between their armrests, and tapped the back of John’s knuckles with her own.

“You nearly took his Italian leather toes off,” Erin said, the corner of her mouth curving upward.

“He was standing in the ADA turning lane,” John replied, the tension in his jaw finally softening as he handed her one of the warm paper cups of apple cider from his tray. “Come on, Erin. The nine-forty-five bus to Progress Street is boarding at Bay 1.”

Side by side, their electric motors humming in matched harmony, John and Erin rolled out under the limestone arches of the colonnade toward the glowing amber lights of the transit center—together, and all the way home.